

## **TOPIC 5: Philippine-American War**

### **List of Reading Materials:**

- **Account of Private William Grayson**
- **Address Adopted by Anti-Imperialist League**
- **Aguinaldo's Declaration of War**
- **Aguinaldo's Declaration of Surrender**
- **Benevolent Assimilation Proclamation**
- **Cartas Sobre La Revolucion**
- **Diary of Lt. Ernest Motsch**
- **Letter of Henry Thompson to his parents**
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### **Introduction to the Philippine-American War**

On 04 February 1899, two days prior to the US Congress' ratification of the 1898 Treaty of Paris war broke-out between the forces of the first Philippine Republic headed by President Emilio F. Aguinaldo and the American Forces in the country. The war was regarded as a continuation of the ongoing 1896 Philippine Revolution, while the United States simply regarded the conflict as an insurrection. The war led to the deaths of Filipino combatants and the fall of the first Philippine Republic. The war officially ended in July 1902.

This section contains primary and secondary sources that will help the students enrich their understanding and learning of the significant events that transpired during the Filipino-American War. Primary sources such as the account of Private William Grayson, Aguinaldo's Declaration of War, and the Address Adopted by Anti-Imperialist League provide a glimpse into the early parts of the war. On the other hand, secondary sources on the Filipino-American War in this section provides a historiographical understanding of the event.

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### **Account of Private William Grayson <sup>19</sup>**

The Treaty of Paris of 1898 ended the Spanish-American War and decided on the fate of Spain's remaining colonies including the Philippines. For this, it was also of great importance to the Filipinos who had been fighting for their independence since 1896. Unfortunately, its contents were finalized without consulting with Aguinaldo's government, thereby amplifying suspicions regarding the true motives of the Americans in the Philippines. This eventually led to the outbreak of the Philippine-American War on February 4, 1899 – an event previously called the “San Juan Bridge Incident.” Further investigations later revealed that the first shot of the war occurred in Silencio cor. Sociego Streets in Santa Mesa, Manila.<sup>20</sup>

One of the primary sources regarding this event was from Private William Walter Grayson, an American volunteer soldier of the First Nebraska Volunteer Infantry. From his own recollection of the encounter, it becomes clear that it was Grayson himself who fired the first shot which killed two Filipino soldiers. According to Teodoro Agoncillo, General Arthur MacArthur issued his order to advance against the Filipinos the day after this incident without even properly investigating the cause of the firing, thereby beginning the Philippine-American War.<sup>21</sup>

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Private William Grayson, in an interview, said of this important incident:

“About eight o'clock, (Private Orville) Miller and I were cautiously pacing our district. We came to a fence and were trying to see what the Filipinos were up to. Suddenly, near at hand, on our left, there was a low but unmistakable Filipino outpost signal whistle. It was immediately answered by a similar whistle about twenty-five yards to the right. Then a red lantern flashed its signal from blockhouse No. 7. We had never seen such a sign used before.

In a moment something rose slowly up not twenty-five feet in front of us. It was a Filipino. I yelled ‘halt’ made it pretty loud, for I was accustomed to challenging the officer of the guard in

Edwin Wildman, *Aguinaldo: A Narrative of Filipino Ambitions* (Boston, Massachusetts: Lothrop<sup>19</sup> Publishing Company, 1901), p. 195-196, accessed 25 October 2020, <http://name.umdl.umich.edu/ahz9331.0001.001>.

National Historical Institute, “Board Resolution 07, S. 2003: Authorizing the Transfer of the<sup>20</sup> Historical Marker for the Site of the First Shot of the Philippine-American War from San Juan Bridge to Silencio corner Sociego St., Sta. Mesa, Manila,” accessed 25 October 2020, <https://drive.google.com/file/d/0B9c6mrXl4zoYRjU5VUVzRk1jaWs/view>.

Teodoro Agoncillo, *History of the Filipino People*, 8<sup>th</sup> edition (Quezon City: C&E Publishing,<sup>21</sup> Inc., 2012), p. 226.

approved military style. I challenged him with another loud 'halt.' Then he shouted 'halto' to me. Well, I thought the best thing to do was to shoot him. He dropped. If I didn't kill him, I guess he died of fright. Then two Filipinos sprang out of the gateway about fifteen feet from us. I called 'halt' and Miller fired and dropped one. I saw that another was left. Well, I think I got my second Filipino that time.

We retreated to where our six other fellows were, and I said: 'Line up, fellows; the " niggers" are in here all through these yards.' We then retreated to the pipe line and got behind the water main and stayed there all night. It was some minutes after our second shots before the Filipinos began firing."

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*Address Adopted by the Anti-Imperialist League, February 10, 1899*<sup>22</sup>

In December 1898, US President William McKinley first openly declared his decision to annex the Philippines in his *Benevolent Assimilation Proclamation* which was shortly followed by the ratification of the Treaty of Paris on February 6, 1898. And while this plan to take over the Philippines received significant support from many Americans, a number of prominent citizens of the country, many of whom were politicians and intellectuals, still fearlessly expressed their opposition to the measure. In June 1898, these dissenters, which included former president Grover Cleveland, former senator George S. Boutwell, Stanford University's founding president David Starr Jordan, writer Mark Twain, and steel magnate and philanthropist Andrew Carnegie, formed the Anti-Imperialist League.

As a response to Filipino-American hostilities, this Boston-based league released a statement on February 10, 1898 which criticized the expansionist ideals of the US government as largely inconsistent with the founding principles of their country. It also warned that any further move to be committed by the Americans pertinent to the Philippines might endanger the security not only of the US but as well as of the entire world. The statement likewise beseeched the US government to acknowledge Aguinaldo as the rightful president of the Philippines and its congress as a legitimate representation of the people similar to the Continental Congress of the 13 British Colonies which later became the United States. In the end, the members of the league demanded the US government to withdraw its military forces from the Philippines and to instead recognize its independence.

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10 February 1899

The full ratification of the Treaty with Spain will cause a technical change in the relations of the United States to the Philippine Islands, but will afford no- reason for any change of the purposes of the Anti-Imperialists in regard to the future of the islands, nor will it in the least affect the clear duty of this Republic.

We are now engaged in warfare with the inhabitants of those islands. It is unprofitable to discuss the question as to which party began hostilities. No other result could have been expected, when the lines of two opposing military forces were held so close and in such tense condition that little was needed to cause an explosion.

<sup>22</sup> Anti-Imperialist League, *Address Adopted by the Anti-Imperialist League, February 10, 1899* (Boston, Massachusetts: Anti-Imperialist League, 1899), accessed 25 October 2020, <https://archive.org/details/addressadoptedby00anti>.

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Certain facts, however, are beyond dispute: that Aguinaldo was brought to the islands by our own warship, that his aid was accepted and desired in our military operations against the Spaniards, and that hopes of independence were encouraged by our consuls and other officers. It is equally indisputable that a parliament of the islands, organized by representatives elected by 186 towns and provinces, chose Aguinaldo President and framed a constitution, which was promulgated, defining the powers and duties of the separate departments of the government with remarkable clearness and ability; that the government so formed beyond a doubt represented fairly the people of the islands and probably with quite as much fairness as the Continental Congress in Philadelphia, in 1775, represented the people of the thirteen States.

It is also undeniable that on January 5 President McKinley issued a proclamation through General Otis, declaring that on the 10<sup>th</sup> of the previous month the Philippine Islands had been ceded to this country by Spain by the signature of the Treaty of Paris, and further ordered him to extend the military government of the United States ‘to the whole of the ceded territory,’ and to demand the surrender of Iloilo, which was then held by the Filipinos in an orderly manner by capture from the Spaniards.

It cannot be claimed in law that this assumption of power was warranted in advance of the ratification of the Treaty by both parties, and there can be no doubt that the arbitrary claim greatly aggravated the people of the islands, whose hope of independence seemed thus rudely destroyed.

No declaratory resolution as to the future of the islands was assented to by the Administration

before the ratification of the Treaty by the Senate, and none has been made since.

Any right that we assert to ownership of the Philippines must rest, therefore, either upon conquest or upon purchase from their Spanish oppressors, or upon both, and in any case it is, as we believe, inconsistent with the principles of this Republic, and fraught with danger to its peace and to the peace of the world.

The first result we already witness, a war of subjugation, which must embitter the people we seek to rule, and which, however successful, must bring disaster and death to our soldiers, and unmeasured cost to our people.

Profoundly impressed with the seriousness of the situation, it is the purpose of the Anti Imperialists to continue the circulation of literature, to assist in the formation of leagues, and by public meetings, and every proper means known to a free people, to agitate for the revival in the

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land of the spirit of Washington and Lincoln, to protest against a spirit of militarism and force, to oppose the colonial idea and a permanently large standing army, and to assert the vital truths of the Declaration of Independence embodied in the Constitution and indissolubly connected with the welfare of this Republic.

They urge, therefore, all lovers of freedom, without regard to party associations, to cooperate with them to the following ends:

*First.* That our government shall take immediate steps towards a suspension of hostilities in the Philippines and a conference with the Philippine leaders, with a view to preventing further bloodshed upon the basis of a recognition of their freedom and independence as soon as proper guarantees can be had of order and protection to property.

*Second.* That the Congress of the United States shall tender an official assurance to the inhabitants of the Philippine Islands that they will encourage and assist in the organization of such a government in the islands as the people thereof shall prefer, and that upon its organization in stable manner the United States, in accordance with its traditional and prescriptive policy in such cases, will recognize the independence of the Philippines and its equality among nations, and gradually withdraw all military and naval forces.

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**President Emilio Aguinaldo's Declaration of War on the United States (Malolos, Bulacan on February 4, 1899)**

Following the conflict that erupted between the Philippine and American forces on 04 February 1899, at around nine o' clock p.m. President Emilio Aguinaldo received a communication from the Caloocan station regarding the event. He issued a declaration to the Filipino people saying that he had taken necessary actions to preserve the friendly ties between the Filipinos and the American forces, however, he said that the national integrity must be preserved as well. In this declaration, he also recognized that the American forces who were acting as friends and liberators unjustly attacked the Filipino forces. Aguinaldo issued three commands in his declaration: first, he ordered that all peace and friendly relations between the Filipino and American forces be severed and the latter be treated as enemies; second, the captured Americans will be treated as prisoners of wars; and lastly, the declaration must be copy furnished to all the consuls in Manila and the Congress.

A copy of Aguinaldo's declaration is available in John Taylor's Philippine Insurgent Records. Taylor was a member of the United States Army in the Philippines. He was given appointed to be in charge of all the records seized by the American forces during the Philippine-American War. A compilation of these records came to known later on as the Philippine Insurgent Records.

**Excerpt:**

Nine o'clock p.m., this date, I received from Caloocan station a message communicated to me that the American forces, without prior notification or any just motive, attacked our camp at San Juan del Monte and our forces garrisoning the block-houses around the outskirts of Manila, causing the losses among our soldiers, who in view of this unexpected aggression and of the decided attack of the aggressors, were obliged to defend themselves until the firing became general all along the line. No one can deplore more than I this rupture of friendly relations. I have a clear conscience that I have endeavored to avoid it at all costs, using all my efforts to preserve friendship with the army of occupation, even at the cost of not a few humiliations and many sacrificed rights. But it is my unavoidable duty to maintain the integrity of the national honor and that of the army so unjustly attacked by those who, posing as our friends and liberators, attempted to dominate us in place of the Spaniards, as is shown by the grievances enumerated in my manifesto of January 8th last; such as the continued outrages and violent exactions committed against the people of Manila, the useless conferences, and all my frustrated efforts in favor of peace and concord.

Summoned by this unexpected provocation, urged by the duties imposed upon me by honor and patriotism and for the defense of the nation entrusted to me, calling on God as a witness of my good faith and the uprightness of my intentions, I order and command:

1. Peace and friendly relations between the Philippine forces and the American forces of occupation are broken, and the latter will be treated as enemies, within the limits prescribed by the laws of war.
2. American soldiers who may be captured by the Philippine forces will be treated as prisoners of war.
3. This proclamation shall be communicated to the accredited consuls of Manila, and to Congress, in order that it may accord the suspension of the constitutional guaranties and the resulting declaration of war.

Given at Malolos, February 4, 1899.

**EMILIO AGUINALDO**

General-in-Chief